Speaking on the agreements, Ratan said that the group now had a ‘unified brand’ it could leverage. ‘There were many products that could have been branded but were not branded in the past because it didn’t seem to matter. Now we have put a strong focus on what we could brand.’ He added: ‘The signing is just the formality of it … There is on the branding side for the first time a discipline of forcing companies to adhere to, [to] conform.’

The agreement had multiple goals and cast responsibilities on Tata Sons as the promoter as well as the individual companies. Tata Sons was legally committed to protecting the overall interests of the subscribing companies and undertaking, as required, steps to protect the Tata brand, researching business strategies, and promoting brands. The subscription to BEBP depended on the type of agreement a particular company signed.

Following the launch of the BEBP agreement, Tata Sons finalized a uniform logo for use by the subscribing companies, which was unveiled on 14 February 1999. Designed by Wolff Olins, a British design agency, the new logo—a blue oval with a white ‘T’—symbolized the group’s ‘strategy to forge a common corporate identity’. The ‘T and A’ were meant to ‘represent precision and the future, which could also be seen as a fountain of knowledge’, commented the design agency in a case study. The Tata logo could, however, be only used under certain conditions prescribed by Tata Sons.

The brand had a clear meaning. ‘It was associated most strongly with the group’s best-performing or most promising units,’ the design agency said. Through this symbolization, the brand enhanced the reputation of the products of the lesser-known companies by bringing to the minds of the customers the superior products of the companies that had earned such a reputation. ‘There was perhaps a call to refresh whatever marks we had into one unified acceptable mark that would in fact promote the group,’ Ratan asserted.

The new logo, however, sent the media into a frenzy, which Ratan described as much ado about nothing. He discouraged attempts to ‘read any kind of symbolism’ or ‘some kind of intangible meaning’ into the logo. He appealed for the new logo to be viewed simply ‘as a mark that either one can view abstractly or as a rendition of the “T” [and] as a mark that’s a recognizable mark signifying a Tata Group company’.

The BEBP agreement had also enjoined the signing companies to make some other commitments. Ratan in a very nimble way had made it